AyurvedAI

AI-powered Ayurvedic knowledge and healthcare information system

Ayurvedic Health Topics

15 sample topics for AyurvedAI: doshas and constitution, daily and seasonal routine, common problems with causes, diet, lifestyle, traditional herbs, modern view and warning signs, plus Panchakarma and diet rules.

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Important: This document is for education and information only. It does not diagnose, treat or prescribe, and it gives no personal doses. Always consult a qualified Ayurvedic doctor (BAMS) or physician before using any herb or therapy, especially in pregnancy, with prescription medicines, or with liver, kidney, heart or autoimmune disease. In an emergency call 112 (India) or 108 (ambulance).

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How to read this document

Each topic follows a similar order: overview, causes, diet and lifestyle, traditional herbs, modern view and red flags, then common questions. Every paragraph begins with the topic name so that it can be understood on its own.

Source note. The content summarises standard Ayurvedic textbook knowledge from the Charaka Samhita, Sushruta Samhita and Ashtanga Hridaya, with plain modern medical context. Individual claims were not checked online for this sample set, classical texts sometimes disagree with one another, and the content is awaiting review by a qualified Ayurvedic expert. Verify with primary sources and the Ayurvedic Pharmacopoeia of India before any clinical or academic use.

Terms used

Dosha: The three functional principles of the body: Vata, Pitta and Kapha.

Prakriti and vikriti: Birth constitution and current imbalance.

Agni and ama: Digestive fire, and the undigested residue formed when agni is weak.

Dhatu: Body tissue (seven in total).

Pathya and apathya: Wholesome and unwholesome food and habits.

Rasayana: Rejuvenating therapy or tonic.

Churna, kwatha, taila, ghrita, vati, asava and arishta: Powder, decoction, medicated oil, medicated ghee, tablet, and fermented medicines.

BAMS: Bachelor of Ayurvedic Medicine and Surgery, the basic degree of an Ayurvedic doctor in India.

Doshas and Prakriti

Tridosha and Prakriti

AYU-T01
Foundations of Ayurveda

Doshas and Prakriti - summary: What Vata, Pitta and Kapha are, what body constitution (prakriti) means, how it differs from the current imbalance (vikriti), and how much of this is supported by modern science.

Doshas and Prakriti - Overview: Ayurveda describes the living body through three functional principles called doshas: Vata, Pitta and Kapha (together the Tridosha). They work with seven tissues (dhatus: rasa, rakta, mamsa, meda, asthi, majja, shukra) and three waste products (malas: stool, urine, sweat). The Sushruta Samhita defines a healthy person (swastha) as one whose doshas, digestive fire (agni), tissues and waste elimination are in balance, and whose senses, mind and self are content. Disease is understood as a loss of that balance (vaishamya).

Doshas and Prakriti - Vata dosha: Vata is made of air and space. Its qualities are dry, light, cold, rough, subtle and mobile. Its main seat is the colon (pakvashaya), and it also acts in the thighs, hips, ears, bones and skin. Vata governs all movement: breathing, blinking, heartbeat, nerve impulses, speech, movement of food and elimination. It has five subtypes: Prana, Udana, Samana, Vyana and Apana. When Vata is aggravated, people tend to have dryness, constipation, gas, anxiety, poor sleep, cracking joints and a feeling of cold. Vata is strongest in old age, in the dry cold season, and at about 2 to 6 in the afternoon and early morning.

Doshas and Prakriti - Pitta dosha: Pitta is made of fire and a little water. Its qualities are hot, sharp, light, slightly oily, liquid and spreading. Its main seat is the stomach and small intestine, and it also acts in the liver, blood, eyes and skin. Pitta governs digestion, metabolism, body heat, vision, complexion, courage and intelligence. It has five subtypes: Pachaka, Ranjaka, Sadhaka, Alochaka and Bhrajaka. When Pitta is aggravated, people tend to have acidity, heartburn, skin rashes, sweating, loose stools, irritability and anger. Pitta is strongest in middle age, in summer and early autumn, and at about 10 to 2 in the day and night.

Doshas and Prakriti - Kapha dosha: Kapha is made of water and earth. Its qualities are heavy, slow, cool, oily, smooth, dense, soft and sticky. Its main seat is the chest and stomach, and it also acts in the joints, head and fat tissue. Kapha gives structure, lubrication, stability, stamina and calmness. It has five subtypes: Avalambaka, Bodhaka, Tarpaka, Kledaka and Shleshaka. When Kapha is aggravated, people tend to have weight gain, congestion, excess mucus, heaviness, laziness and too much sleep. Kapha is strongest in childhood, in late winter and spring, and at about 6 to 10 in the morning and evening.

Doshas and Prakriti - Prakriti: your constitution: Prakriti is the natural constitution formed at conception, shaped (according to the Charaka Samhita) by the parents' health, the season, the womb and the mother's diet and lifestyle. There are seven types: Vata, Pitta, Kapha, Vata-Pitta, Pitta-Kapha, Vata-Kapha and the balanced type Sama (all three equal). Prakriti is said to stay the same for life. It guides which foods, routines and climates suit a person best.

Doshas and Prakriti - Prakriti versus vikriti: Prakriti is the lifelong baseline. Vikriti is the present state of imbalance, which can change from week to week with food, season, stress, sleep and illness. A person with a Pitta prakriti can have a Kapha vikriti after a cold, wet winter and heavy food. Ayurvedic treatment aims to correct the vikriti while respecting the prakriti.

Doshas and Prakriti - Typical tendencies (only tendencies, not a diagnosis): Vata type: slim, light frame, dry skin, cold hands, irregular appetite and sleep, quick and creative, easily worried. Pitta type: medium build, warm body, strong appetite and thirst, sharp mind, determined, quick to anger, early greying or hair thinning. Kapha type: sturdy or heavy build, smooth oily skin, slow steady appetite, calm, good stamina, deep sleep, gains weight easily. Most people are a mix, and one feature alone does not decide the type.

Doshas and Prakriti - How the doshas are balanced: The basic rule is that like increases like and opposites balance. Vata is calmed by warm, moist, grounding food, regular routine, oil massage and enough rest. Pitta is calmed by cooling, calming foods that taste sweet, bitter or astringent, by avoiding excess heat, spice and anger, and by rest in the shade. Kapha is calmed by light, warm, dry and stimulating food, activity, and pungent, bitter and astringent tastes. These are general lifestyle principles for healthy people and not a treatment for any disease.

Doshas and Prakriti - Modern scientific view: Modern medicine does not recognise doshas as physical structures, and there is no accepted test for them. Some Indian research groups study whether prakriti types relate to genetic and metabolic differences (a field called Ayurgenomics), but the results are early and not clinically established. Online dosha quizzes are not clinically validated. A trained Ayurvedic doctor (BAMS) assesses prakriti and vikriti through history, pulse (nadi), tongue, appetite, bowel habit and general examination.

Doshas and Prakriti - When to see a doctor: Knowing your dosha is useful for everyday diet and routine, but it must never delay medical care. Chest pain, sudden weakness, severe breathlessness, high fever, blood in stool or vomit, or any sudden severe symptom needs urgent medical help. In India call 112 or 108.

Common questions about Doshas and Prakriti

Question about Doshas and Prakriti: Can my dosha change?
Answer: Your prakriti (birth constitution) is considered fixed, but your vikriti (current imbalance) changes with diet, season, age, stress and illness. That is why a person can feel more Vata in autumn and more Kapha in spring.

Question about Doshas and Prakriti: What is the difference between prakriti and vikriti?
Answer: Prakriti is the constitution you are born with and stays for life. Vikriti is the present imbalance that treatment tries to correct.

Question about Doshas and Prakriti: Is an online dosha quiz reliable?
Answer: No. Online quizzes give only a rough idea of tendencies. A proper assessment is done by a qualified Ayurvedic doctor in person, and modern science has not validated the dosha types.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine)

Dinacharya

AYU-T02
Lifestyle (Swasthavritta)

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - summary: The classical Ayurvedic daily routine from waking to sleeping, what each habit is for, who should be careful, and how it matches modern sleep and meal-timing advice.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - Overview: Dinacharya means daily regimen. The Charaka Samhita (Sutrasthana chapter 5) and the Ashtanga Hridaya (Sutrasthana chapter 2) describe a routine that keeps the doshas balanced and the digestive fire (agni) strong in healthy people. The idea is that a regular rhythm in waking, cleaning, eating, working and sleeping prevents disease more cheaply than treating it later.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - Waking up: Classical texts advise waking in Brahma muhurta, roughly one and a half hours before sunrise (about 4:30 to 5:30 am in most of India). Waking early is linked with the clear, light quality of Vata time and a fresh mind. A healthy adult can start with waking at a fixed time and gradually move earlier. People who are ill, very weak, pregnant, elderly or who work night shifts should not force an early wake-up at the cost of sleep.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - Morning cleansing: After passing urine and stool (natural urges should never be suppressed), the routine includes brushing the teeth with a bitter, astringent or pungent twig or a herbal powder (dantadhavana), scraping the tongue with a smooth metal scraper (jihva nirlekhana), and rinsing the mouth. Oil pulling (gandusha or kavala) means holding a spoonful of sesame or coconut oil in the mouth for a few minutes and then spitting it out. Never swallow it, spit it in the dustbin and not the sink, and do not use it for children who cannot spit. Small studies suggest oil pulling may reduce plaque, but it does not replace brushing and flossing.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - Oil massage (abhyanga): Abhyanga is a gentle massage of the whole body, scalp and feet with warm oil before bathing. Sesame oil is common for Vata and Kapha, and coconut oil is common for Pitta. Classical texts say regular abhyanga reduces dryness and fatigue and improves sleep and skin. Skip it during fever, indigestion, acute cold with congestion, or just after meals, and use a gentle oil if the skin is sensitive. Do a small patch test first.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - Exercise (vyayama): Vyayama should be done up to half of one's capacity (ardha shakti), which is said to be reached when sweat appears on the forehead, nose and armpits and breathing becomes faster through the mouth. Morning is best, especially for Kapha. Classical texts say proper exercise brings lightness, strength, good digestion and reduces fat, but excess exercise causes thirst, exhaustion, breathlessness and fever. Avoid heavy exercise when hungry, right after meals, or when unwell. Yoga, brisk walking and surya namaskar suit most healthy adults.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - Bathing, meals and work: A warm or lukewarm bath on the body (cooler for the head) is advised after exercise. The main meal is best taken at midday, around 12 to 1 pm, when digestion is strongest (Pitta time). Dinner should be light, warm and finished at least two to three hours before bed. Eat only when hungry, in a calm place, without hurry, and do not skip meals regularly.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - Evening and sleep: Evening is for light activity, family time and a lighter meal. Going to bed by about 10 pm is advised so that the body sleeps before the active Pitta period of the night. Avoid screens and heavy food close to bedtime. A foot massage with warm sesame oil or ghee before sleep is a traditional aid to sleep.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - Sample daily schedule: 5:30 am wake, warm water, pass stool. 6:00 am tongue scraping, oil pulling, brushing. 6:15 am yoga or walking, pranayama. 7:15 am oil massage and bath. 8:00 am light breakfast. 12:30 pm main meal. 4:30 pm light snack and a walk. 7:30 pm light dinner. 9:00 pm wind down, foot massage, no screens. 10:00 pm sleep. This is only an example and should be adapted to work, age and health.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - Modern link: Modern research supports regular sleep and wake times, regular meal times, morning daylight and daily physical activity because they support the body clock (circadian rhythm), blood sugar and mood. Many dinacharya habits fit this, although individual practices such as oil pulling have limited

evidence.

Dinacharya (Daily Routine) - Cautions: Dinacharya is a lifestyle guide for healthy people, not a treatment for disease. People with diabetes, heart disease, pregnancy, skin disease or on regular medicines should check with their doctor before changing exercise, fasting or massage habits.

Common questions about Dinacharya (Daily Routine)

Question about Dinacharya (Daily Routine): What is the best time to wake up according to Ayurveda?
Answer: Brahma muhurta, about one and a half hours before sunrise (roughly 4:30 to 5:30 am), provided you still get enough sleep.

Question about Dinacharya (Daily Routine): Is oil pulling safe?
Answer: It is generally safe for healthy adults if the oil is spat out and never swallowed. Do not give it to young children who cannot spit, and it does not replace brushing.

Question about Dinacharya (Daily Routine): Should I do abhyanga every day?
Answer: Many healthy people do it daily or a few times a week. Skip it during fever, indigestion or a heavy cold, and avoid very oily massage if you have a Kapha imbalance with heaviness.

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine)

Ritucharya

AYU-T03
Lifestyle (Swasthavritta)

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine) - summary: How diet and habits change with the six Indian seasons, which dosha builds up in each season, and why the 14-day transition between seasons matters.

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine) - Overview: Ritucharya means seasonal regimen. Ayurveda says the body, the digestive fire and the doshas change with the seasons, so diet and lifestyle should change too. The Charaka Samhita (Sutrasthana chapter 6) and the Ashtanga Hridaya (Sutrasthana chapter 3) divide the year into six seasons (ritus), each of about two months. The dates below are approximate and vary with region and local weather.

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine) - The six seasons: Shishira (late winter, about mid-January to mid-March), Vasanta (spring, mid-March to mid-May), Grishma (summer, mid-May to mid-July), Varsha (monsoon, mid-July to mid-September), Sharad (autumn, mid-September to mid-November) and Hemanta (early winter, mid-November to mid-January). The first three belong to Adana kala (the sun draws moisture and strength, so the body becomes drier and weaker). The last three belong to Visarga kala (strength returns and the body is nourished).

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine) - Hemanta and Shishira (winter): Digestion is strong in the cold, so the body can handle heavier, nourishing, warm food such as ghee, sesame, jaggery, nuts, wheat and soups. Oil massage, sun exposure, warm clothes and regular exercise are advised. Avoid cold wind, cold drinks and fasting. Kapha slowly accumulates in this period, which prepares the ground for spring congestion.

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine) - Vasanta (spring): The accumulated Kapha melts with the rising heat and aggravates, so colds, congestion, allergies and heaviness are common. Prefer light, dry, warm food: barley, old grains, mung dal, honey, bitter and pungent vegetables, ginger and pepper. Avoid heavy sweets, curd, cold drinks and daytime sleep. Exercise and dry powder massage (udvartana) are helpful. Traditional practitioners use vamana therapy in spring for Kapha disorders, but only under supervision.

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine) - Grishma (summer): The sun saps strength and Vata starts to build. Prefer sweet, cool, liquid and slightly oily food: rice, milk, buttermilk, coconut water, seasonal fruits and plenty of fluids. Avoid too much salt, sour and pungent food, alcohol and heavy exercise in the heat. The Charaka Samhita allows a short daytime sleep in summer because nights are short and the body is drained.

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine) - Varsha (monsoon): Digestive fire is weakest and Vata aggravates in the damp, cool weather, and infections spread through water and food. Prefer light, warm, freshly cooked food, old grains, soups with ginger, cumin and black pepper, and boiled or purified water. Avoid raw salads, street food, stale food, daytime sleep and getting wet. Basti (medicated enema therapy) is traditionally done in this season, only by a trained practitioner.

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine) - Sharad (autumn): The sun comes out after the rains and the stored Pitta aggravates, so acidity, skin rashes, fever, irritability and sunburn are common. Prefer food with sweet, bitter and astringent taste: rice, wheat, mung dal, ghee, bitter gourd, amla, pomegranate, and cool water. Avoid curd, oily fried food, sour and salty items and midday sun. Traditional treatments for Pitta, such as virechana and bloodletting, are only for qualified practitioners. Classical texts praise water warmed by the sun in the day and cooled by moonlight at night (hamsodaka).

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine) - Ritusandhi: the 14-day transition: The last seven days of one season and the first seven days of the next are called ritusandhi. Ayurveda advises changing diet and habits gradually in this window, giving up the old pattern a little each day and adopting the new one a little each day. A sudden change is said to upset the body and cause seasonal illness.

Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine) - Modern link: Modern medicine also sees seasonal patterns: viral colds and allergies in spring, dehydration and heat illness in summer, dengue, malaria and waterborne illnesses in the monsoon, and fever and skin problems in autumn. Hygiene, safe water, vaccinations and hydration are the proven protections, and Ritucharya should be used along with them.

Common questions about Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine)

Question about Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine): Which season aggravates Kapha?
Answer: Vasanta, the spring season, when the Kapha stored in winter melts and aggravates. This is why spring colds and congestion are common.

Question about Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine): What should I eat in the monsoon according to Ayurveda?
Answer: Light, warm, freshly cooked food such as soups, khichdi and old grains with ginger, cumin and pepper, and boiled water. Avoid raw salads, street food and stale food.

Question about Ritucharya (Seasonal Routine): Why is ritusandhi important?
Answer: Ritusandhi is the 14-day transition between seasons. Changing food and habits slowly during this period is said to prevent seasonal illness.

Digestive Problems and Agni

Agni, Ajirna, Amlapitta, Vibandha

AYU-T04
Common health problem

Digestive Problems and Agni - summary: Indigestion, acidity, constipation, loose stools and bloating explained through agni and ama, with diet, lifestyle and traditional herbs, plus clear warning signs for a doctor.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Overview: In Ayurveda, digestion depends on agni, the digestive fire. The Ashtanga Hridaya says that most diseases begin when agni is weak. Undigested, sticky waste material called ama forms when food is not digested well, and ama is considered the root of many problems. Strengthening agni (deepana) and clearing ama (pachana) are the first steps in treating most digestive complaints.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Four states of agni: Sama agni is balanced: good appetite, comfortable digestion, regular stool. Vishama agni (Vata type) is irregular: sometimes hungry, sometimes not, with gas, bloating and alternating constipation and loose stool. Tikshna agni (Pitta type) is too sharp: strong hunger, burning, acidity, loose stool. Manda agni (Kapha type) is slow: little appetite, heaviness, nausea, mucus, sluggishness after meals.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Common digestive problems: Ajirna is indigestion, which the texts divide into four kinds: from ama (heaviness, belching), from Pitta (sour burning belching), from Vata (pain and gas) and from slow digestion (rolling sleepiness). Amlapitta is excess acidity, similar to hyperacidity or reflux. Vibandha or malabaddhata is constipation. Atisara is diarrhoea. Grahani is a chronic disorder of the small intestine, with features like irritable bowel syndrome and malabsorption. Adhmana is bloating.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Causes (nidana): Irregular meal times, overeating, eating again before the last meal is digested (adhyashana), cold drinks with meals, heavy or oily food at night, mixing incompatible foods, fried and packaged food, too much tea or coffee on an empty stomach, alcohol, suppressing natural urges, night waking, anger, worry and stress are all described as causes.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Signs of ama: A thick white coating on the tongue, heaviness and tiredness after meals, bad breath, loss of appetite, a feeling of fullness, sticky stool that sticks to the toilet, and body ache are signs that ama is present. Heavy, oily, cold food should be avoided until these signs clear.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Diet for indigestion and weak agni: Eat warm, fresh, light food: khichdi made with rice and moong dal, thin moong soup, rice with ghee, vegetable soups. Ginger (a thin slice with a pinch of rock salt before meals) is a classical appetizer. Cumin, coriander and fennel tea (CCF tea), ajwain and black pepper help gas and bloating. Buttermilk (takra) with roasted cumin and rock salt is a classical digestive for the daytime, though it is not advised at night or in strong Pitta symptoms. Avoid cold drinks, fried and packaged food, heavy sweets and eating late.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Constipation (Vibandha): Mostly a Vata problem. Traditional advice: drink warm water through the day, eat fibre-rich vegetables, fruits and whole grains, add a little ghee, keep fixed meal and toilet times, and do not suppress the urge. Triphala churna at night is the classical gentle laxative, and Haritaki and psyllium husk (isabgol) are also used. Castor oil (eranda taila) should only be used under a practitioner's advice. Long-term constipation needs a medical check.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Acidity (Amlapitta): Prefer bitter, sweet and astringent foods: cooked gourds, coconut water, soaked raisins, pomegranate, amla, rice, mung dal, and cool but not iced drinks. Avoid sour, fermented, spicy, fried food, tea and coffee on an empty stomach, alcohol and smoking. Eat at regular times, do not lie down for two to three hours after eating, and raise the head of the bed. Classical formulations used by practitioners include Avipattikara churna, along with Shatavari, Amla and Yashtimadhu. Yashtimadhu (licorice) can raise blood pressure and lower potassium, so it needs caution in high blood pressure.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Loose stools and diarrhoea: Drink plenty of fluid and oral rehydration solution. Light foods such as rice water, banana and curd rice are used in traditional care. Bilva (bael) and Kutaja are classical herbs used by practitioners. Infants, young children, older people and anyone who is weak must see a doctor early, because dehydration can be dangerous.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Modern view: Modern medicine classes many of these problems as functional dyspepsia, gastro-oesophageal reflux, irritable bowel syndrome and constipation. Ginger has reasonable evidence for nausea, and small studies suggest Triphala can help mild constipation, but large high-quality trials are lacking. Helicobacter pylori infection, celiac disease, thyroid problems, medicines and other causes should be ruled out when symptoms persist.

Digestive Problems and Agni - Red flags: see a doctor: Black or bloody stools, vomiting blood, severe or constant abdominal pain, trouble or pain on swallowing, unexplained weight loss, a new digestive problem after the age of about 45, symptoms lasting more than two weeks, high fever, signs of dehydration (very dry mouth, dizziness, very little urine), or yellow eyes need urgent medical evaluation.

Common questions about Digestive Problems and Agni

Question about Digestive Problems and Agni: Is Triphala safe to take every day?
Answer: Triphala is generally well tolerated and many people take it at night for mild constipation, but it can cause loose stools and cramps. Avoid it in pregnancy and in diarrhoea, and check with a doctor if you take regular medicines.

Question about Digestive Problems and Agni: What is the best food when I have indigestion?
Answer: Warm, light, freshly cooked food such as moong dal khichdi or thin moong soup, with a little ginger, cumin and ghee. Skip cold drinks, fried food and heavy sweets until digestion improves.

Question about Digestive Problems and Agni: Does cold water weaken digestion?
Answer: Classical Ayurveda says very cold drinks, especially with meals, dull agni, and recommends warm or room-temperature water. Modern evidence for this is limited, but many people with bloating or reflux feel better with warm drinks.

Sleep and Insomnia

Nidra and Anidra

AYU-T05
Common health problem

Sleep and Insomnia - summary: Why sleep is one of the three pillars of health in Ayurveda, how Vata, Pitta and Kapha affect sleep, an evening routine, traditional herbs, and warning signs that need medical care.

Sleep and Insomnia - Overview: Nidra (sleep) is one of the three pillars of life (trayopastambha) in Ayurveda, together with food (ahara) and disciplined living (brahmacharya). The Charaka Samhita (Sutrasthana chapter 21) says that happiness and unhappiness, nourishment and thinness, strength and weakness, knowledge and ignorance, and even life and death depend on proper or improper sleep. Anidra (also called nidranasha) means loss of sleep, similar to insomnia.

Sleep and Insomnia - Causes of Anidra: Aggravated Vata or Pitta, worry, grief, anger, overwork, too much mental stimulation, caffeine and nicotine, heavy or late dinner, irregular routine, long screen time at night, hunger, pain and chronic illness. The texts also say that suppressing the natural urge to sleep or staying awake at night weakens digestion and increases Vata.

Sleep and Insomnia - Sleep and the doshas: Vata type of sleeplessness: trouble falling asleep, light broken sleep, racing thoughts, waking at 2 to 4 am, dry skin and constipation. Pitta type: waking hot and sweating around 1 to 3 am, with work or anger thoughts, thirst or hunger. Kapha type: not insomnia but too much sleep (atinidra), with heaviness, a groggy morning and daytime drowsiness.

Sleep and Insomnia - Evening routine for better sleep: Keep a fixed bedtime, ideally by about 10 pm. Finish a light, warm dinner two to three hours before bed. Take a warm bath. Massage the soles of the feet with warm sesame oil or ghee (padabhyanga), and a little oil on the scalp, which is a traditional sleep aid. Dim the lights and put away phones and laptops an hour before sleep. Keep the room dark, cool and quiet. A cup of warm milk is a traditional bedtime drink for people who digest milk well.

Sleep and Insomnia - Herbs used traditionally: Ashwagandha (stress and Vata), Brahmi, Jatamansi, Tagara, Shankhapushpi and Mandukaparni are used by practitioners to calm the mind. Jatamansi is a threatened wild plant, so buy only from certified cultivated sources. Sarpagandha is a potent prescription-strength herb that lowers blood pressure and must never be self-medicated. Nutmeg in very large amounts is toxic. Herbal sedatives can add to the effect of sleeping tablets, alcohol and antidepressants, so tell your doctor about them.

Sleep and Insomnia - Yoga and breathing: Gentle yoga in the evening, such as forward bends, legs-up-the-wall (viparita karani), child pose, and relaxation in shavasana, helps the body unwind. Yoga nidra, slow alternate-nostril breathing (nadi shodhana) and humming-bee breath (bhramari) calm the nervous system. Avoid vigorous exercise within two hours of bedtime.

Sleep and Insomnia - Daytime sleep: Classical texts advise against sleeping in the daytime (divaswapna) for most people because it increases Kapha, causing heaviness, headache and slow digestion. Exceptions are summer, children, the elderly, people who are weak, ill or recovering, and those who have lost sleep at night.

Sleep and Insomnia - Modern view: Most adults need seven or more hours of sleep. For chronic insomnia, cognitive behavioural therapy for insomnia (CBT-I) and good sleep habits are the recommended first treatment. Studies on ashwagandha for sleep show modest benefit, mostly in people with insomnia and at higher doses over a longer time, but the overall evidence is not strong, and rare liver injury has been reported with ashwagandha products. Caffeine, alcohol and screens before bed worsen sleep.

Sleep and Insomnia - Red flags: see a doctor: Trouble sleeping on most nights for more than three weeks, loud snoring with pauses in breathing or gasping (possible sleep apnoea), sudden sleep attacks in the day, uncontrollable leg movements at night, low mood or hopeless thoughts, hallucinations, or drowsiness while driving need a medical check. If you have thoughts of harming yourself, contact emergency services (112) or the Tele-MANAS mental health helpline in India at 14416.

Common questions about Sleep and Insomnia

Question about Sleep and Insomnia: How many hours of sleep do I need?
Answer: Most adults need seven or more hours each night. Ayurveda also stresses sleeping at a regular time, ideally by about 10 pm.

Question about Sleep and Insomnia: Does warm milk before bed help sleep?
Answer: It is a traditional Ayurvedic habit and many people find it soothing, though the scientific evidence is limited. Avoid it if milk upsets your stomach.

Question about Sleep and Insomnia: Can I take ashwagandha every night for sleep?
Answer: Many people use it for short periods, but evidence is modest and rare liver problems are reported. Avoid it in pregnancy and with liver or thyroid disease, and speak to a doctor if you take other medicines.

Stress and Anxiety

Chittodvega, Manas Roga

AYU-T06
Common health problem
(mind)

Stress and Anxiety - summary: How Ayurveda looks at stress and anxiety (mind, Vata, sattva), daily practices, calming herbs, and when professional mental health care is needed.

Stress and Anxiety - Overview: Ayurveda treats mind and body as one. The mind (manas) has three qualities (gunas): sattva (clarity and calm), rajas (activity and restlessness) and tamas (dullness and inertia). Stress and anxiety are described as rising rajas with aggravated Vata, giving worry, restlessness, fear and a racing mind. Anxiety is close to the Ayurvedic idea of chittodvega, and low mood and hopelessness to vishada. Ayurveda says mental health and physical health affect each other through the gut, sleep and energy.

Stress and Anxiety - Common signs: Constant worry, fear, restlessness, trouble concentrating, irritability, poor sleep, tense muscles, palpitations, dry mouth, stomach upset, loss of appetite or comfort eating, and feeling overwhelmed. In Ayurvedic terms Vata type stress shows as anxiety and insomnia, Pitta type as anger, irritability and burnout, and Kapha type as withdrawal, heaviness and low motivation.

Stress and Anxiety - Causes and triggers: Overwork, lack of sleep, skipping meals, too much caffeine, constant phone and news use, loneliness, unresolved grief or anger, irregular routine, excess cold dry food and suppression of emotions. Charaka lists wrong use of the mind, senses and time (pragyaparadha, asatmyendriyartha samyoga and parinama) as the main causes of illness.

Stress and Anxiety - Daily practices: Keep a regular routine for waking, meals and sleep. Do oil massage (abhyanga), especially of the scalp and feet. Practise slow breathing such as nadi shodhana (alternate-nostril) and bhramari. Do meditation or quiet sitting for 10 to 20 minutes, yoga or walking in daylight, and spend time in nature. Reduce caffeine, alcohol and late-night screens. Satvic living means fresh, simple vegetarian-style food, good company and a calm environment, which classical texts link with a clear mind.

Stress and Anxiety - Diet: Prefer warm, freshly cooked, grounding food such as rice, moong dal, ghee, cooked vegetables, soaked almonds and warm milk if tolerated. Avoid skipping meals, too much tea and coffee, very spicy, stale or packaged food and alcohol. Regular meals keep Vata steady and calm the mind.

Stress and Anxiety - Traditional herbs (medhya rasayana): Brahmi, Mandukaparni, Shankhapushpi, Yashtimadhu and Guduchi are the four classical medhya rasayanas (mind tonics) described in the Charaka Samhita. Ashwagandha, Jatamansi and Tagara are also used to calm stress. These are used by practitioners as supportive measures. Herbs can interact with antidepressants, sedatives and thyroid medicines and some can affect the liver, so tell your doctor before using them.

Stress and Anxiety - Sattvavajaya chikitsa: Sattvavajaya is the Ayurvedic mental therapy that strengthens the mind through counselling, reassurance, discipline, values, restraint of the mind from harmful thoughts and conduct, and practices of meditation. It is comparable in spirit to modern psychotherapy and mindfulness.

Stress and Anxiety - Modern view: Modern medicine recognises generalised anxiety disorder, panic disorder, depression and burnout as treatable conditions. Regular exercise, sleep, mindfulness, yoga, breathing practices and psychotherapy (especially cognitive behavioural therapy) have good evidence for stress and mild anxiety. Evidence for ashwagandha is tentative: some trials suggest benefit for anxiety at 300 to 600 mg of extract a day for about three months, but the overall evidence is not enough to be sure of safety or benefit.

Stress and Anxiety - Red flags: get professional help: Anxiety or low mood that lasts more than two weeks, panic attacks, inability to work or sleep, use of alcohol or drugs to cope, hearing voices or severe confusion, or any thought of harming yourself or ending your life needs help from a doctor or mental health professional. In India call Tele-MANAS (14416) or 112 for emergencies. Do not stop prescribed psychiatric medicines on your own.

Common questions about Stress and Anxiety

Question about Stress and Anxiety: What does Ayurveda say causes anxiety?
Answer: Aggravated Vata and a restless mind (high rajas), usually triggered by irregular routine, poor sleep, overwork, cold dry food, caffeine and emotional stress.

Question about Stress and Anxiety: Which herbs are traditionally used for stress?
Answer: Ashwagandha, Brahmi, Jatamansi, Shankhapushpi and Mandukaparni. They are supportive only, and you should check with a doctor first, especially if you take other medicines.

Question about Stress and Anxiety: Can Ayurveda replace medicine for depression or severe anxiety?
Answer: No. Ayurvedic lifestyle and herbs can support wellbeing, but moderate to severe anxiety or depression needs a doctor or mental health professional, and prescribed medicines should not be stopped without medical advice.

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes

Twak Roga, Yuvanapidika, Kandu, Kushta

AYU-T07
Common health problem

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes - summary: Acne, itching, eczema-like rashes and dull skin explained through Pitta, Kapha and blood (rakta), with diet, lifestyle, traditional herbs and warning signs.

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes - Overview: In Ayurveda the skin (twak) is the seat of touch and is nourished by the blood tissue (rakta) and affected by Pitta. Most skin diseases are grouped under Kushta (major) and Kshudra roga (minor). The root causes are said to be aggravated doshas, impure blood, weak digestion and wrong diet. Common problems include acne (yuvanapidika), itching (kandu), eczema-like rashes (vicharchika), urticaria or hives (sheetapitta), fungal infection (dadru) and dry cracked skin.

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes - Acne (Yuvanapidika): Acne appears as pimples on the face, chest and back, mostly in teenagers and young adults. Ayurveda links it to aggravated Kapha and Pitta with Vata, with blocked skin pores. Triggers include oily and fried food, sweets, too much dairy for some people, hot spicy food, irregular sleep, constipation, stress and the use of oily cosmetics. Face washing twice a day with a mild cleanser and not squeezing pimples are basic advice.

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes - Itching and rashes: Dry itching with scaling is usually Vata. Itching with redness, burning and pus is usually Pitta. Wet oozing itching with thickness is usually Kapha. The cause may be allergy, infection, insect bite, heat, soap, fabric, medicine or stress, and these must be identified before treatment.

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes - Diet (pathya) for the skin: Eat fresh, simple food rich in vegetables, bitter gourd, drumstick, gourds, mung dal, rice, wheat, pomegranate, amla and plenty of water. Avoid or reduce fried, very spicy, sour, salty and fermented food, packaged snacks, sweets, curd at night, excess tea and coffee, alcohol and incompatible food combinations (viruddha ahara) such as milk with fish or milk with sour fruit.

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes - Lifestyle: Keep the skin clean and dry, use mild soap, wear loose cotton clothes, avoid scratching, sleep on time, treat constipation, avoid suppressing natural urges, manage stress and protect the skin from strong sun. Wash towels and pillow covers often. Do not use cosmetic creams or kitchen ingredients such as lemon or toothpaste on active acne because they can burn and scar.

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes - Traditional herbs and formulations: Neem, Manjistha, Haridra (turmeric), Khadira, Chandana (sandalwood), Sariva, Guduchi, Aragwadha and Triphala are classical blood purifiers (rakta shodhaka). Formulations such as Mahamanjishtadi kwatha, Khadirarishta, Panchatikta ghrita and Gandhaka rasayana are used by practitioners. Turmeric or sandalwood paste is a traditional external application, but test a small patch first. Neem oil is toxic to small children and to be avoided in pregnancy.

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes - Cleansing therapies: In stubborn cases, practitioners may suggest purification such as virechana (medicated purgation) or bloodletting (raktamokshana, including leech therapy). These are only for trained doctors, never for home use.

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes - Modern view: Dermatology treats acne, eczema, psoriasis and fungal infection with proven topical and oral medicines. Diet may matter for some people: high glycaemic food and skimmed milk have been linked with acne in some studies. Evidence for herbs such as neem and turmeric in skin disease is preliminary. Allergic contact reactions to herbal pastes and oils are possible.

Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes - Red flags: see a doctor: Painful nodules or cysts and scarring, a rash that spreads fast or covers large areas, blisters, fever with rash, swelling of the lips or face or trouble breathing (emergency), a mole that changes shape or bleeds, a non-healing sore, yellow crusts or pus (infection), or any rash in an infant. Do not stop prescribed medicines for eczema, psoriasis or acne on your own.

Common questions about Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes

Question about Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes: What causes acne according to Ayurveda?
Answer: Aggravated Kapha and Pitta with blocked pores, often triggered by oily, fried and sweet food, constipation, irregular sleep, stress and hormonal changes.

Question about Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes: Which foods should I avoid with skin problems?
Answer: Fried, very spicy, sour and salty food, sweets, packaged snacks, alcohol, curd at night and incompatible combinations such as milk with fish. Eat simple fresh meals with plenty of vegetables and water.

Question about Skin Problems: Acne, Itching and Rashes: Is turmeric paste good for acne?
Answer: Turmeric or sandalwood paste is a traditional application, but it can stain and may cause allergy, so test a small patch first. Evidence is limited, and severe acne needs a dermatologist.

Hair Fall and Scalp Care

Khalitya, Palitya, Indralupta

AYU-T08
Common health problem

Hair Fall and Scalp Care - summary: Hair fall, early greying and patchy hair loss in Ayurveda, scalp-oil care, diet, herbs like Bhringaraja and Amla, and the modern medical causes that must be checked.

Hair Fall and Scalp Care - Overview: Ayurveda describes hair as a by-product (mala) of the bone tissue (asthi dhatu) and links hair health with Pitta, blood and digestion. Hair fall is called khalitya, premature greying palitya, and sudden patchy hair loss indralupta (similar to alopecia areata). Aggravated Pitta, which burns the hair roots, and aggravated Vata, which dries them, are the main causes in classical texts.

Hair Fall and Scalp Care - Causes: According to Ayurveda: anger, stress, grief, lack of sleep, very hot, spicy, sour or salty food, smoking, alcohol, hot baths, exposure to strong sun, constipation and poor digestion. In modern terms the main causes are iron deficiency, vitamin D and B12 deficiency, low protein intake, thyroid disease, polycystic ovary syndrome, hormonal change after childbirth (postpartum shedding), crash diets, fever or illness, certain medicines, hair treatments and tight hairstyles, and genetics (androgenetic alopecia).

Hair Fall and Scalp Care - Scalp oil massage (shiro abhyanga): Regular gentle massage of the scalp with warm oil is the main classical advice. Common oils are coconut oil, sesame oil, Bhringaraja taila, Neelibhringadi taila, Amla taila and Brahmi oil. Massage for five to ten minutes, leave for 30 minutes to a few hours, and wash with a mild shampoo. Do not leave heavy oil on during fever, cold with congestion or on an infected scalp. Do a patch test first for allergy.

Hair Fall and Scalp Care - Diet for healthy hair: Eat enough protein (dal, legumes, milk products, eggs, nuts, seeds if you eat them), iron-rich food (leafy greens, dates, jaggery, sesame, pomegranate, beetroot) with a vitamin C source such as amla or lemon, healthy fats such as ghee, nuts and sesame, and drink enough water. Avoid crash diets, excess tea and coffee, very spicy and fried food and long gaps between meals.

Hair Fall and Scalp Care - Traditional herbs: Bhringaraja (Eclipta alba), Amla, Brahmi, Hibiscus (japakusuma), Neem, Jatamansi, Shatavari and Ashwagandha are used internally or in oils by practitioners. Triphala is used for digestion and detox. Take internal herbs only on professional advice, because some interact with medicines and some (such as Ashwagandha) have been linked with rare liver problems.

Hair Fall and Scalp Care - Hair care habits: Wash hair two to three times a week with a mild shampoo, avoid very hot water, do not comb wet hair roughly, avoid tight ponytails, heat styling and chemical treatments, protect the scalp from strong sun, and keep combs clean. Sleep seven or more hours and manage stress.

Hair Fall and Scalp Care - Greying and dandruff: Early greying is linked in Ayurveda with Pitta and in modern medicine with genetics, vitamin B12 deficiency, stress and smoking. Amla, Bhringaraja and a nourishing diet are traditional supports, but they cannot reverse genetic greying. Dandruff (darunaka) is usually a yeast-related scalp condition, helped by neem or hibiscus rinses and anti-dandruff shampoos.

Hair Fall and Scalp Care - Modern view: Normal hair fall is 50 to 100 strands a day. Treatable causes such as iron or thyroid problems should be tested before hair oil is blamed. Minoxidil and other medical treatments have good evidence for pattern baldness, while evidence for herbal oils is limited and mostly from small studies. Hair growth takes three to six months to show improvement.

Hair Fall and Scalp Care - Red flags: see a doctor: Sudden heavy shedding, round bald patches, scalp redness, scaling, pain, pus or scarring, hair loss together with tiredness, weight change, irregular periods, or new hair loss after starting a medicine. Hair loss in children also needs a doctor.

Common questions about Hair Fall and Scalp Care

Question about Hair Fall and Scalp Care: Which oil is best for hair fall in Ayurveda?
Answer: Bhringaraja taila, Amla taila, Neelibhringadi taila and plain coconut or sesame oil are traditional. Choose by scalp type and patch test first. Oil massage helps scalp health but will not fix a deficiency or hormonal cause.

Question about Hair Fall and Scalp Care: How many hairs fall in a day normally?
Answer: Around 50 to 100 strands a day is normal. More than that for several weeks, or visible thinning, deserves a medical check.

Question about Hair Fall and Scalp Care: Can Amla and Bhringaraja stop greying?
Answer: They are traditional hair tonics and may support hair health, but they cannot reverse greying caused by genetics. Check vitamin B12 and thyroid levels if greying starts very early.

Joint Pain and Arthritis

Sandhigata Vata, Amavata, Vatarakta

AYU-T09
Common health problem

Joint Pain and Arthritis - summary: Osteoarthritis-like (Sandhigata Vata), rheumatoid-like (Amavata) and gout-like (Vatarakta) joint problems in Ayurveda, with diet, oil therapies, herbs and what a doctor must check.

Joint Pain and Arthritis - Overview: Joint pain in Ayurveda is mainly a Vata disorder. Three groups matter: Sandhigata Vata, where aggravated Vata dries and wears the joint, similar to osteoarthritis, usually after middle age; Amavata, where ama (undigested residue) and Vata lodge in the joints with swelling, stiffness and fever, similar to rheumatoid arthritis; and Vatarakta, where Vata and impure blood cause burning pain, redness and swelling, often in the big toe, similar to gout.

Joint Pain and Arthritis - Sandhigata Vata symptoms: Pain that increases with movement and walking, stiffness after rest that eases quickly, a crackling sound in the joint (crepitus), swelling that comes and goes, and difficulty with stairs and squatting. The knees, hips, spine and fingers are most affected. Causes include ageing, dry cold exposure, overexertion, injury, obesity and poor nutrition.

Joint Pain and Arthritis - Amavata symptoms: Pain and swelling of many joints, often both sides, with morning stiffness lasting more than an hour, heaviness, loss of appetite, low fever, thirst and tiredness. Treatment first aims to digest ama with light food and digestive herbs such as ginger (shunthi) before oily or strengthening treatment is given. Giving heavy oily treatment too early is said to worsen it, so a practitioner must guide it.

Joint Pain and Arthritis - Vatarakta symptoms: Sudden severe pain, redness, heat and swelling in a joint, often the big toe at night, with burning and itching. Diet linked to attacks includes red meat, organ meat, alcohol (especially beer), sugary drinks, sour, salty and fermented food and dehydration.

Joint Pain and Arthritis - Diet: For Sandhigata Vata, take warm, freshly cooked, slightly oily food such as soups, khichdi with ghee, sesame, cooked vegetables and enough protein, and avoid cold, dry, raw and very bitter food. For Amavata, begin with light warm food such as rice gruel (peya), moong soup and ginger tea, and avoid curd, heavy, cold and fried food. For Vatarakta, avoid red meat, alcohol, fermented and very sour or salty food, and drink plenty of water.

Joint Pain and Arthritis - External therapies: Warm oil massage with oils such as Mahanarayana taila or Dhanvantaram taila, local steam (swedana), Janu basti (warm oil held on the knee in a dough ring), Kati basti for the lower back and Patra pinda sweda (herbal leaf bolus) are used for Vata-type joint pain. They should be done by trained therapists and not in acute hot, red, swollen joints or in fever.

Joint Pain and Arthritis - Herbs and formulations: Shallaki (Boswellia serrata), Guggulu (Yogaraj guggulu, Simhanada guggulu), Rasna, Nirgundi, Dashamoola, Ashwagandha, Guduchi, Shunthi and Eranda taila are classical. Turmeric and ginger are common kitchen supports. Guggulu can interact with thyroid and blood-thinning medicines, and herbs that contain heavy metals (bhasma preparations) need a certified source and a practitioner's advice.

Joint Pain and Arthritis - Movement and weight: Gentle regular movement is important: walking, swimming, cycling, yoga and strengthening of the thigh muscles protect the knee. Losing extra weight reduces stress on the knees and hips. Avoid squatting and sitting cross-legged for long periods if it hurts, and use warm pads for stiffness.

Joint Pain and Arthritis - Modern view: Osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis and gout are different diseases with different treatments. Rheumatoid arthritis and gout need proper medical drugs to prevent permanent joint damage. Some trials suggest Boswellia and turmeric extracts may modestly reduce osteoarthritis pain, but the evidence is limited. Blood tests (ESR, CRP, rheumatoid factor, anti-CCP, uric acid) and X-rays help the doctor decide.

Joint Pain and Arthritis - Red flags: see a doctor: A hot, red, very swollen joint, especially with fever (possible infection or gout), swelling of several small joints with morning stiffness over an hour, sudden inability to move a joint, joint pain after an injury, numbness or weakness in the leg, or pain with unexplained weight loss. Never stop prescribed arthritis or gout medicines on your own.

Common questions about Joint Pain and Arthritis

Question about Joint Pain and Arthritis: What is Sandhigata Vata?
Answer: It is the Ayurvedic term for degenerative joint pain, similar to osteoarthritis, caused mainly by aggravated Vata with dryness and wear of the joint.

Question about Joint Pain and Arthritis: What is Amavata?
Answer: Amavata is a joint disease caused by ama (undigested residue) and Vata, with swelling, stiffness and tiredness, comparable to rheumatoid arthritis. It must be diagnosed by a doctor and treated early.

Question about Joint Pain and Arthritis: Does turmeric help knee pain?
Answer: Some small studies suggest turmeric or curcumin extracts may modestly ease knee osteoarthritis pain, but evidence is limited. High-dose supplements have caused rare liver injury, so use them with your doctor's knowledge.

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle

Prameha, Madhumeha

AYU-T10
Chronic condition

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle - summary: How Ayurveda describes diabetes (Prameha and Madhumeha), the lifestyle and diet advice, traditional herbs, and why medical treatment and blood sugar checks must continue.

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle - Overview: Prameha is a group of twenty urinary disorders in the Charaka Samhita (Chikitsasthana chapter 6), divided by dosha into ten Kaphaja, six Pittaja and four Vataja types. Madhumeha, the Vataja type with sweet, honey-like urine, corresponds closely to diabetes mellitus. Classical texts say Kapha-type Prameha is easier to treat, while Vataja Madhumeha is hard to cure. They describe two origins: inherited (sahaja) and caused by lifestyle (apathyanimittaja).

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle - Causes in Ayurveda: Sedentary lifestyle, daytime sleep, heavy, sweet, oily and cold food, new rice, curd, milk sweets, jaggery and sugar in excess, lack of exercise, obesity, and family history. These match modern risk factors for type 2 diabetes: overweight, inactivity, unhealthy diet and heredity.

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle - Symptoms: Frequent urination, excessive thirst, increased hunger, tiredness, weight loss despite eating, blurred vision, slow-healing wounds, frequent infections, tingling or numbness in the feet, and sweet-smelling or ant-attracting urine in classical descriptions. Many people with type 2 diabetes have no symptoms early, so screening is important.

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle - Diet (pathya): Classical advice: barley (yava), old wheat and rice in moderate amounts, millets, mung dal, other pulses, bitter and astringent vegetables such as bitter gourd, fenugreek leaves, drumstick and bottle gourd, and amla. Reduce sugar, sweets, refined flour, sugary drinks, fried food, white bread, large portions and late heavy dinners. Eat at fixed times and avoid snacking all day.

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle - Lifestyle: Daily exercise is central: brisk walking, cycling, yoga or swimming for at least 150 minutes a week, which is also the modern recommendation. Avoid daytime sleep, keep a healthy weight, sleep well, manage stress, quit smoking and limit alcohol. Look after the feet daily and keep skin clean to prevent wounds.

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle - Traditional herbs: Vijaysar (Pterocarpus marsupium), Gudmar (Gymnema sylvestre), Methi seeds, Jamun seeds, Karela (bitter gourd), Guduchi, Haridra with Amla (Nishamalaki), Shilajit and Triphala are used. The formulation Chandraprabha vati is traditional for urinary disorders. These herbs can lower blood sugar further, so with diabetes medicines there is a risk of hypoglycaemia (low sugar), and some herbal products have been found to contain hidden prescription drugs.

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle - Safety rule: Never stop or reduce insulin or diabetes tablets such as metformin on your own because of an Ayurvedic treatment. Tell your doctor about every herb you take, and check blood sugar regularly. Herbs are at best supportive; evidence for most herbs in diabetes is limited or inconsistent.

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle - Modern view: Type 2 diabetes is managed with diet, exercise, weight loss, medicines and sometimes insulin, with regular checks of HbA1c, kidney function, eyes and feet. Diagnosis is by fasting glucose of 126 mg/dl or more, HbA1c of 6.5 percent or more, or a random value of 200 mg/dl or more with symptoms, confirmed by a doctor. Good control prevents complications in the eyes, kidneys, nerves and heart.

Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle - Red flags: urgent care: Very high blood sugar with vomiting, abdominal pain, fruity breath, fast breathing, drowsiness or confusion (possible ketoacidosis), very low blood sugar with sweating, shaking, confusion or fainting, a foot wound that is red, swollen or not healing, sudden vision loss, chest pain, or new numbness need urgent medical care. In India call 112 or 108.

Common questions about Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle

Question about Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle: What is Madhumeha?
Answer: Madhumeha is the Ayurvedic name for the Vataja type of Prameha with sweet urine, which corresponds to diabetes mellitus.

Question about Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle: Can Ayurveda cure diabetes?
Answer: Type 2 diabetes cannot be reliably cured by herbs. Ayurvedic diet and lifestyle can support control, but medical treatment and blood sugar monitoring must continue.

Question about Diabetes (Madhumeha) and Lifestyle: Which foods are good for diabetes in Ayurveda?
Answer: Barley, millets, mung dal, bitter gourd, fenugreek, drumstick, bottle gourd and amla, with less sugar, sweets, refined flour and fried food.

Obesity and Weight Management

Sthaulya, Medoroga

AYU-T11
Common health problem

Obesity and Weight Management - summary: Sthaulya (obesity) in Ayurveda: causes, Kapha and fat tissue (meda), diet and exercise, traditional herbs, and the modern body-size cut-offs for Indians.

Obesity and Weight Management - Overview: Sthaulya means excess body bulk. The Charaka Samhita (Sutrasthana chapter 21) lists the over-stout person (atisthula) as one of eight undesirable body types (ashtauninditiya), because such a person is prone to reduced lifespan, low strength, sweating, bad smell, excess hunger and thirst, and low vitality. Ayurveda explains Sthaulya as excess fat tissue (meda dhatu) blocking channels, with Kapha aggravated and digestion either sharp or disturbed.

Obesity and Weight Management - Causes: Overeating, heavy, sweet, oily and cold food, too much sugar, curd, new grains and milk sweets, lack of exercise, daytime sleep, not working the mind or body, genetic tendency, and suppressed emotions. Modern causes also include hormonal and thyroid disease, medicines such as steroids, poor sleep, stress and processed food.

Obesity and Weight Management - How obesity is measured: For Asian Indians, health risk begins at lower body size than in Western charts. A body mass index (BMI) of 23 to 24.9 is considered overweight and 25 or more is obese. A waist of more than 90 cm in men and more than 80 cm in women means abdominal obesity and a higher risk of diabetes and heart disease. BMI is a screening tool and does not suit athletes, children, pregnant women or the elderly.

Obesity and Weight Management - Ayurvedic principle of treatment: Treatment is called apatarpana (reducing therapy) and must be gentle. It uses light, dry, warm, bitter, pungent and astringent food, regular exercise, dry powder massage (udvartana, for example with horse gram or barley flour) and herbs that reduce fat (medohara). Extreme fasting and crash diets are not advised, because they weaken agni and aggravate Vata.

Obesity and Weight Management - Diet: Eat warm, freshly cooked, light food in moderate quantity: barley, millets, jowar, bajra, ragi, mung dal, horse gram, plenty of vegetables, bitter gourd, drumstick, gourds, buttermilk, and spices such as ginger, black pepper, cumin and turmeric. Stop eating when about three-quarters full. Avoid sugar, sweets, sugary drinks, refined flour, fried food, heavy dairy sweets, curd at night, and late dinners. Chew slowly and avoid snacking between meals.

Obesity and Weight Management - Lifestyle: Do exercise daily until light sweating, such as brisk walking for 45 to 60 minutes, yoga (surya namaskar, trikonasana), cycling or swimming. Avoid daytime sleep. Sleep seven hours at night. Spend less time sitting and stand or walk every hour. Keep a regular meal time and reduce stress eating.

Obesity and Weight Management - Traditional herbs and formulations: Triphala, Trikatu (ginger, black pepper, long pepper), Guggulu preparations (Medohara guggulu, Navaka guggulu), Vidanga, Musta, Guduchi and Arogyavardhini vati are classical. Warm water with a little honey in the morning is a classical home remedy; honey should never be heated or cooked. These herbs should be used under a practitioner, and guggulu can interact with thyroid and blood-thinning medicines.

Obesity and Weight Management - Modern view: Weight loss is achieved by a steady calorie deficit through diet and activity, aiming for about 0.5 to 1 kg a week, with good sleep and stress control. Medical, drug and surgical options exist for severe obesity. Evidence for Ayurvedic herbs for weight loss is limited, and products sold for fast weight loss may be unsafe or contain hidden drugs.

Obesity and Weight Management - Red flags: see a doctor: Rapid weight gain, swelling of the face or legs, extreme tiredness, cold intolerance (possible thyroid disease), irregular periods with excess facial hair (possible PCOS), shortness of breath on light activity, snoring with pauses in breathing, chest pain, high blood pressure or high blood sugar, or unexplained weight loss. Children and teenagers with obesity need a paediatrician.

Common questions about Obesity and Weight Management

Question about Obesity and Weight Management: What is Sthaulya?
Answer: Sthaulya is the Ayurvedic term for obesity, caused by excess fat tissue and aggravated Kapha, usually from heavy food, inactivity and daytime sleep.

Question about Obesity and Weight Management: What BMI is overweight for Indians?
Answer: A BMI of 23 to 24.9 is overweight and 25 or above is obese for Asian Indians, and a waist of more than 90 cm in men or 80 cm in women signals abdominal obesity.

Question about Obesity and Weight Management: Is honey and warm water good for weight loss?
Answer: It is a classical home remedy and is harmless for most people in small amounts, but there is little strong evidence that it causes weight loss. Never heat the honey, and avoid it if you have diabetes unless your doctor agrees.

Cough, Cold and Immunity

Kasa, Pratishyaya, Vyadhikshamatva

AYU-T12
Common health problem

Cough, Cold and Immunity - summary: Common cold, cough and breathlessness (Pratishyaya, Kasa, Shwasa) and the Ayurvedic idea of immunity (ojas, bala), with home care, herbs and warning signs including when a cough could be serious.

Cough, Cold and Immunity - Overview: Pratishyaya is the common cold and nasal congestion, Kasa is cough and Shwasa is breathlessness, and Tamaka Shwasa is similar to asthma. The Charaka Samhita describes five kinds of Kasa: Vataja (dry cough with pain), Pittaja (yellow sputum with burning), Kaphaja (heavy, wet cough with white mucus), Kshataja (from injury to the chest) and Kshayaja (from wasting disease). Most colds and coughs are caused by viruses and settle by themselves in about a week.

Cough, Cold and Immunity - Immunity in Ayurveda: The idea close to immunity is vyadhikshamatva, the body's power to resist disease and to stop a disease from becoming strong. It depends on ojas, the subtle essence of all tissues, and on bala (strength). Bala may be sahaja (inborn), kalaja (by season and age) or yuktikrita (earned through right food, exercise, sleep and tonics). Good digestion, sound sleep, a calm mind and regular exercise are said to build ojas.

Cough, Cold and Immunity - Common cold and congestion: Home care in traditional practice: warm fluids, ginger-tulsi tea, rest, steam inhalation (nadi sweda) with plain hot water or a few leaves of tulsi or ajwain, warm food such as soup or khichdi, and salt-water gargles for sore throat. Avoid cold drinks, ice cream, curd at night, cold air on the head and chest, and sleeping in air-conditioning draught. Steam must be taken carefully to avoid burns, and children should not be left alone with hot water.

Cough, Cold and Immunity - Cough remedies: For dry cough, warm water with a little ghee or honey, liquorice (Yashtimadhu) lozenges and warm milk are used. For wet cough, ginger, black pepper, long pepper (pippali), tulsi, Vasa (Adhatoda vasica), Kantakari and Sitopaladi churna with honey are common practitioner remedies. Talisadi churna is also classical. Honey must not be given to infants under 12 months because of the risk of infant botulism.

Cough, Cold and Immunity - Building immunity: Eat fresh seasonal food with fruits and vegetables, enough protein, and include amla (a rich source of vitamin C), turmeric, ginger and garlic in cooking. Sleep seven hours, exercise daily, get sunlight, manage stress and avoid smoking and heavy alcohol. Chyawanprash (Agastya rasayana) is a traditional tonic of amla and many herbs, but it contains a lot of sugar, so people with diabetes should use it only after a doctor's advice. Keep vaccinations up to date; Ayurvedic tonics do not replace vaccines.

Cough, Cold and Immunity - Breathlessness and asthma: Asthma and chronic lung disease need proper medical diagnosis and inhalers or medicines, which must not be stopped without the doctor's advice. Pranayama, yoga and avoiding triggers (dust, smoke, cold air, certain foods) can support treatment. Ayurvedic herbs such as Pippali, Vasa and Haridra are used by practitioners as adjuncts.

Cough, Cold and Immunity - Modern view: Most coughs and colds are viral and do not need antibiotics. Rest, fluids and honey (for children over one year) help cough. Zinc, vitamin C and steam inhalation have limited evidence. Chyawanprash and herbs are not proven to prevent infection. Wearing a mask, hand washing, vaccination and clean air help.

Cough, Cold and Immunity - Red flags: see a doctor: Cough for more than three weeks (tuberculosis and other serious illness must be checked, especially with fever, night sweats, weight loss or blood in sputum), blood in sputum, breathlessness or wheeze, chest pain, high fever for more than three days, bluish lips, a child with fast or noisy breathing or refusing feeds, or a cough in a person with heart disease, diabetes or weak immunity. Call 112 or 108 in severe breathlessness.

Common questions about Cough, Cold and Immunity

Question about Cough, Cold and Immunity: What is Pratishyaya?
Answer: Pratishyaya is the Ayurvedic name for the common cold or rhinitis, with a blocked or running nose, sneezing and heaviness of the head.

Question about Cough, Cold and Immunity: Can honey be given to a baby with cough?
Answer: No. Honey must not be given to infants under 12 months because of the risk of infant botulism. For children over one year, a small amount of honey is commonly used for cough.

Question about Cough, Cold and Immunity: Is Chyawanprash good for immunity?
Answer: It is a traditional tonic rich in amla and many people use it daily, but it is high in sugar and there is no strong proof that it prevents infection. Diabetic people should check with a doctor first.

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS

Artava, Kashtartava, Asrigdara, Rajonivritti

AYU-T13
Women's health

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS - summary: Menstrual pain, irregular or heavy periods, PCOS and menopause in Ayurveda, with diet, lifestyle, traditional herbs such as Shatavari, pregnancy cautions and warning signs.

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS - Overview: Ayurveda calls menstrual blood artava and sees a regular, painless period of normal flow as a sign of balanced Vata, Pitta and healthy tissues. The classical terms include Kashtartava or Kricchra artava (painful periods), Asrigdara (excess bleeding), Anartava (absent periods), Artava kshaya (scanty periods) and Rajonivritti (menopause). Pushpaghni jataharini and Artava kshaya are often compared with PCOS.

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS - Painful periods (Kashtartava): Vata is mainly responsible for pain. Warmth, rest, light warm meals, ginger or cumin tea, and a heat pad on the lower abdomen are traditional comforts. Avoid cold food, ice cream, cold drinks and heavy exertion during the period. Gentle yoga such as child pose and cat-cow can help. Many women also benefit from regular exercise and enough sleep through the month.

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS - Heavy bleeding (Asrigdara): Aggravated Pitta is thought to cause heavy bleeding. Cooling, light food, plenty of fluids, and rest are advised. Heavy bleeding can lead to anaemia, so iron-rich food (leafy greens, dates, jaggery, sesame, pomegranate, beetroot, lentils) with vitamin C is important. Herbs such as Lodhra and Ashoka (Saraca asoca) are used by practitioners, and these need a proper diagnosis first because heavy bleeding can have serious causes.

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS - Irregular periods and PCOS: Polycystic ovary syndrome (PCOS) is a hormonal condition with irregular or missed periods, acne, excess facial or body hair, hair thinning and weight gain, often with insulin resistance. Modern care focuses on weight management, exercise, diet and medicines or hormone treatment under a gynaecologist. Ayurveda adds a Kapha-reducing, light, warm diet, regular exercise, yoga, sleep, stress care and herbs such as Shatavari, Ashoka, Lodhra, Kumari (aloe vera) and formulations like Kanchanar guggulu and Dashamoolarishta, all through a practitioner.

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS - Diet for hormonal balance: Prefer whole grains, millets, pulses, vegetables, nuts, seeds, fruit and healthy fats; reduce sugar, refined flour, sugary drinks, fried and processed food. Regular meal times and enough protein help keep blood sugar steady, which is important in PCOS.

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS - Menopause (Rajonivritti): Menopause usually occurs at about 45 to 55 years, and is a Vata-dominant stage of life in Ayurveda. Hot flushes, sleep trouble, mood change and dryness are common. Traditional advice includes warm nourishing food with ghee and sesame, oil massage, yoga and breathing, calcium-rich food, regular exercise, and herbs such as Shatavari. Bleeding after menopause is never normal and must be checked.

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS - Pregnancy and herb safety: Many herbs are not safe in pregnancy or breastfeeding, including Ashoka, Aloe vera, strong purgatives, Guggulu and large amounts of Ashwagandha, Neem, Tulsi and Papaya. A woman who is pregnant or may become pregnant should take herbs only on the advice of a doctor who knows she may be pregnant.

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS - Modern view: A period cycle of 21 to 35 days with bleeding of up to seven days is normal for adults. Painful periods are common; doctors may use pain relief or hormonal treatment and look for endometriosis or fibroids. PCOS is diagnosed by symptoms, hormone tests and ultrasound. Evidence for herbs in menstrual disorders and PCOS is limited, and the care of a gynaecologist should not be replaced.

Women's Health: Periods and PCOS - Red flags: see a doctor: Soaking a pad or tampon every hour for several hours, periods lasting longer than seven days, missed periods when pregnancy is possible, severe pain

not relieved by usual measures, bleeding between periods or after sex, bleeding after menopause, a breast lump, fainting or marked paleness, sudden severe abdominal pain (including a possible ectopic pregnancy), or no periods by the age of 15.

Common questions about Women's Health: Periods and PCOS

Question about Women's Health: Periods and PCOS: What is Kashtartava?
Answer: Kashtartava (or Kricchra artava) is the Ayurvedic term for painful periods, usually linked with aggravated Vata. Warmth, rest and light warm food are traditional comforts.

Question about Women's Health: Periods and PCOS: Is Shatavari good for periods and hormones?
Answer: Shatavari is a traditional tonic for women's health, but evidence is limited. Avoid it without advice in hormone-sensitive conditions and discuss it with a doctor in pregnancy or if you take medicines.

Question about Women's Health: Periods and PCOS: Can Ayurveda treat PCOS?
Answer: Ayurvedic diet, yoga and herbs may support lifestyle management, but PCOS needs a proper diagnosis and care from a gynaecologist or endocrinologist, and prescribed medicines should not be stopped without advice.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy)

Panchakarma, Shodhana

AYU-T14
Therapy

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - summary: The five Panchakarma cleansing therapies, the preparation and aftercare, who should not have them, risks, and how to choose a qualified centre.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - Overview: Panchakarma means five actions. It is the classical Ayurvedic system of purification therapy (shodhana) that removes aggravated doshas and toxins from the body. Panchakarma should be done only by trained Ayurvedic doctors (BAMS or MD Ayurveda) in a proper facility, after assessment of the person's strength, digestion, age, season and disease.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - The five procedures: The Charaka Samhita lists Vamana (therapeutic vomiting), Virechana (medicated purgation), Niruha or Asthapana basti (herbal decoction enema), Anuvasana basti (oil enema) and Nasya (nasal administration of medicated oil or powders). The Sushruta Samhita lists Vamana, Virechana, Basti, Nasya and Raktamokshana (bloodletting). Vamana is mainly for Kapha disorders, Virechana for Pitta disorders and Basti, called the best treatment, for Vata disorders.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - Poorvakarma: preparation: Before the main therapy the body is prepared with digestive herbs (deepana-pachana), internal oleation (snehapana, drinking medicated ghee for a few days in increasing quantity) and external oleation (abhyanga, oil massage) with sweating therapy (swedana, steam). This softens and loosens toxins so that they can be removed. Preparation is as important as the main procedure.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - Pradhana karma: the main therapy: The chosen procedure is given on a set day under supervision. Vamana and Virechana are usually done in the morning after preparation. Basti is given as a course, often 8, 15 or 30 days. Nasya is given by dropping oil into the nostrils after a face massage and steam. The actual duration varies with the disease and the patient and cannot be generalised.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - Paschat karma: aftercare: After vamana or virechana the person follows a graded diet (samsarjana krama) starting with thin rice gruel and slowly returning to normal food over three to seven days. Rest, warm water, avoiding cold, heavy, spicy and oily food, avoiding daytime sleep, suppressing no urges, and avoiding stress and sexual activity during the course are advised. Rasayana (rejuvenation) may follow.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - Who should not take Panchakarma: Pregnant women, very young children and the very old, weak or emaciated persons, people with acute fever, severe diabetes, uncontrolled high blood pressure, heart or kidney failure, bleeding disorders, active infection, severe anaemia or serious illness, and people with a recent surgery. Some procedures, such as vamana, are not suitable for many of these groups. A doctor must decide.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - Risks: Purgation and vomiting can cause dehydration, loss of salts (electrolyte imbalance), low blood sugar, dizziness and weakness. Oil enemas and steam can irritate or burn. Poorly trained therapists, contaminated or heavy-metal-contaminated medicines and unsafe water can cause serious harm. 'Detox' packages without a medical check-up can be unsafe.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - Modern view: There is no strong scientific evidence that Panchakarma removes toxins, and high-quality trials are limited. Some small studies report symptom relief in conditions such as joint pain, but most are low quality. Wellness benefits such as rest, massage and a healthier diet are real but cannot replace medical care.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - Choosing a centre: Look for a registered Ayurvedic physician (BAMS or MD Ayurveda registered with the state or National Commission for Indian System of Medicine), an NABH-accredited hospital or an AYUSH-approved centre, a proper consultation and medical history before treatment, clear written costs, hygienic rooms, and a doctor available throughout. Avoid places that promise to cure serious diseases or ask you to stop your regular medicines.

Panchakarma (Detox Therapy) - Red flags during therapy: Persistent vomiting, severe weakness, fainting, fast heartbeat, severe abdominal pain, blood in stool or vomit, high fever, or very little urine mean stop and seek

urgent medical care.

Common questions about Panchakarma (Detox Therapy)

Question about Panchakarma (Detox Therapy): What are the five Panchakarma procedures?
Answer: Vamana (vomiting), Virechana (purgation), Niruha basti (decoction enema), Anuvasana basti (oil enema) and Nasya (nasal therapy). Some texts include Raktamokshana (bloodletting).

Question about Panchakarma (Detox Therapy): Is Panchakarma safe for everyone?
Answer: No. It is unsuitable in pregnancy, in the very young or old, in weak or very ill people and in several medical conditions. It must be done only after assessment by a qualified Ayurvedic doctor.

Question about Panchakarma (Detox Therapy): What happens before Panchakarma?
Answer: Poorvakarma: digestive herbs, internal oleation with medicated ghee, external oil massage and sweating therapy, which prepare the body for the main procedure.

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules

Ahara, Shadrasa, Viruddha Ahara

AYU-T15
Lifestyle (Swasthavritta)

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - summary: The six tastes (rasa), how to eat according to Ayurveda, incompatible food combinations (viruddha ahara), and how these ideas compare with modern nutrition.

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - Overview: Ahara means food. Ayurveda calls food the first of the three pillars of life and says the right diet is the best medicine. The Charaka Samhita (Vimana Sthana chapter 1) lists eight factors that decide whether a food is suitable (ashtavidha ahara vidhi visheshayatana): its nature, its preparation, the combination, the quantity, the place, the time, the rules of eating and the eater.

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - The six tastes (Shadrasa): Madhura (sweet: grains, milk, ghee, sweet fruits), Amla (sour: lemon, tamarind, curd), Lavana (salty: salt), Katu (pungent: chilli, ginger, pepper), Tikta (bitter: bitter gourd, neem, fenugreek) and Kashaya (astringent: pulses, pomegranate, raw banana, turmeric). Sweet, sour and salty tastes tend to increase Kapha, and pungent, bitter and astringent tastes tend to reduce it. A balanced meal contains all six tastes.

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - Tastes and doshas: Vata is calmed by sweet, sour and salty tastes and increased by pungent, bitter and astringent. Pitta is calmed by sweet, bitter and astringent tastes and increased by sour, salty and pungent. Kapha is calmed by pungent, bitter and astringent tastes and increased by sweet, sour and salty. These are general rules for healthy persons; the full effect also depends on the food's other qualities, its potency (virya) and its after-digestion effect (vipaka).

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - How to eat: Eat only when hungry and after the previous meal has digested. Eat warm, freshly cooked food. Eat in a calm place without hurry, talk or television. Do not eat too fast or too slow. Take an amount that suits your digestion; the Charaka Samhita (Vimana Sthana chapter 2) suggests keeping about one-third of the stomach for solid food, one-third for liquids and one-third empty. Sip warm water with meals instead of large quantities of cold water. Sit and chew well. Avoid eating when angry, grieving or very anxious.

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - Meal timing: Breakfast light, lunch the largest meal around midday when digestion is strongest, and dinner light and early, two to three hours before sleep. Avoid long gaps and constant snacking. Keep a fixed time for meals.

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - Incompatible foods (Viruddha ahara): The Charaka Samhita warns against certain combinations, such as fish with milk, milk with sour fruits or salty food, honey and ghee in equal quantities, honey that has been heated, curd at night, hot food with cold, and reheated or stale food. Classical texts claim such combinations cause skin disease, indigestion and other illness. Modern research has not confirmed most of these claims, but food that is stale or poorly handled can cause food poisoning, and some people have genuine intolerances.

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - Foods to be careful with: Excess fried, oily, sugary and packaged food, cold drinks, ice cream, excess salt, too much tea and coffee, and alcohol. Leftovers should be refrigerated and eaten within a day. Fruit is traditionally taken apart from heavy meals.

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - Pathya and apathya: Pathya means wholesome food and habits that suit a person or disease, and apathya means unsuitable ones. The texts say a person who follows pathya needs no medicine, and a person who does not follow pathya gets no benefit from medicine. This is why diet advice is part of every Ayurvedic treatment.

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - Modern view: Modern nutrition supports many Ayurvedic habits: regular meals, fresh home-cooked food, whole grains, pulses, vegetables, spices, mindful eating and limiting sugar, salt and ultra-processed food. Ideas such as dosha-based diets, avoiding all fruit with milk, or cold water harming digestion lack good scientific evidence. Needs differ with age, pregnancy, allergy, diabetes, kidney disease and other medical

conditions, so a doctor or dietitian should individualise the diet.

Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules - When to see a doctor: Unexplained weight loss, repeated vomiting, a food allergy reaction (swelling of lips or face, hives, wheeze, fainting, which is an emergency: call 112), persistent diarrhoea, blood in stool, severe abdominal pain, or any need for a special diet because of a medical condition.

Common questions about Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules

Question about Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules: What are the six tastes in Ayurveda?
Answer: Madhura (sweet), Amla (sour), Lavana (salty), Katu (pungent), Tikta (bitter) and Kashaya (astringent). A balanced meal includes all six.

Question about Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules: What is viruddha ahara?
Answer: Viruddha ahara means incompatible food combinations, such as fish with milk, heated honey, or honey and ghee in equal quantities, which the classical texts say cause illness. Modern science has not confirmed most of these claims.

Question about Ahara: Diet, Six Tastes and Food Rules: How much should I eat at a meal?
Answer: Charaka suggests one-third of the stomach for solid food, one-third for liquid and one-third left empty, which is roughly eating until about three-quarters full.

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